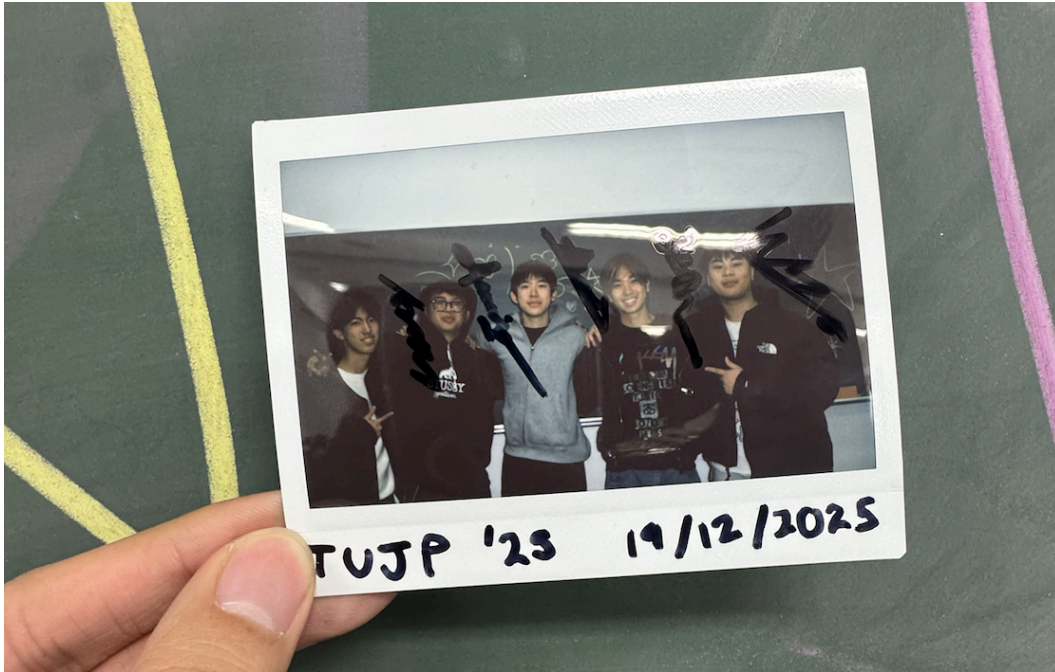




THE UNIVERSITY OF
SYDNEY



OLES2153: In-country Experience Blog

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Before starting this OLE, I did not know too much about Japanese culture, particularly in an educational setting or in a city that was less busy than the major centres I was familiar with. I had very little idea of what Sendai would be like before arriving, and I expected it to feel quite rural and quiet compared to places like Tokyo or Osaka. However, this assumption was quickly challenged. Sendai felt modern, welcoming, and lively, while still maintaining a calmer and more relaxed lifestyle. I was aware of Japan's strong sense of rules, politeness, and food culture before coming, but seeing campus life and how students lived day-to-day was eye-opening. Despite differences in language and customs, I found it comforting that students shared common ground through humour and small jokes, which made interactions feel more human and familiar.

In terms of language learning, my speaking skills improved the most during the program. I became much more confident using Japanese in everyday situations, such as ordering my favourite *famichiki* at convenience stores, asking for prices, or talking to taxi drivers about destinations. Having simple phrases and the confidence to use them made travelling much more enjoyable and meaningful. Learning two different alphabets was challenging and sometimes confusing, but also very rewarding. When I did not understand someone or forgot words, being surrounded by friends made the experience less frustrating and more enjoyable. Interestingly, when I briefly returned to Tokyo and people started speaking English to me, I felt slightly disappointed, as I genuinely enjoyed the challenge and satisfaction of trying to communicate in Japanese and speaking in people's native language.

Cultural immersion was one of the most memorable parts of the OLE. Cleanliness and customer service stood out immediately, as they were much more emphasised compared to what I am used to in Australia and New Zealand. Public transport was also noticeably quieter and more respectful, which contrasted strongly with my usual hectic bus routines back home. I did not often feel like an outsider, and when I spent time with my buddy and my friends' buddies, I felt comfortable and welcomed into the culture.

One particularly meaningful moment occurred at the end of the OLE, when my buddy, Shun, gave me a small gift of snacks and a pen. It was not about the gift itself, but the feeling of being appreciated by someone I had only recently met. Despite language and cultural differences, I formed a genuine connection and a lifelong friendship. This experience taught me that learning a language goes beyond textbooks, it requires real human interaction and shared experiences.

This OLE deepened my understanding of intercultural communication. As someone from an immigrant background, I always valued cultural awareness, but living it daily in another country made it far more real. I became more observant over time and gained a deeper appreciation for values such as respect, consideration, and connection. My biggest takeaway is that connection truly matters. Regardless of differences, we are all human, and being kind to ourselves and others is what ultimately bridges cultures.